

Friday, 18 September 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Light drizzle

20° 13°

BIRMINGHAM

Drizzle

19° 11°

MANCHESTER

Light rain

17° 12°

GLASGOW

Heavy drizzle

15° 11°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1 **Good news for homeowners and borrowers as the Bank of England has held interest rates for the sixth time in a row.**

However, the Bank did signal that a future rise could be on the cards if energy prices remain high. This decision affects millions of mortgages, loans, and savings rates across the UK.

ECONOMY · UK

2 **An RNLI lifeboat station has been forced out of service following anti-migrant protests, sparking concern for coastal safety.**

The Royal National Lifeboat Institution says it hopes to have the station operational again as quickly as possible. This disruption raises questions about the impact of protests on emergency services.

SOCIAL · UK

3 **The Lucy Letby inquiry has released its key findings and recommendations, following the former nurse's conviction for murdering babies.**

Letby is serving 15 whole-life prison terms for murdering seven babies and attempting to murder seven more. The inquiry's report aims to prevent similar tragedies in the future.

CRIME · UK

4 **New research suggests England needs at least seven months of relentless rain to end the current drought conditions.**

Almost three-quarters of England remains in drought after an exceptionally dry spring and summer. This highlights the ongoing challenges posed by climate change and water management.

ENVIRONMENT · UK

5 **The UK Youth Parliament is facing the prospect of being axed, a move that has sparked debate about youth engagement in politics.**

Some argue that scrapping the parliament for 11 to 18-year-olds would be a blow for democracy, while others believe it's an overdue decision. It's a discussion about giving young people a voice.

POLITICS · UK

What's coming up

1

All aboard for a new voice! A 13-year-old boy has been announced as the new voice of Thomas the Tank Engine.

The upcoming Thomas series will also feature 'The Gentleman' actor Henry Golding. It's exciting to see new talent bringing beloved characters to life!

ON AIR – Do you remember your favourite voices from children's TV growing up?

TV · COMING UP

2

Pokémon fans are in a frenzy, queuing up for the highly anticipated 30th-anniversary release of the trading card game.

Avid collectors are calling it 'the biggest day in a decade' for the Japanese phenomenon. It shows the enduring appeal of these classic games.

ON AIR – Were you a Pokémon card collector back in the day, or do you have any favourite childhood crazes?

GAMING · TODAY

3

Charli XCX brought the house down at Reading Festival with an electrifying, era-spanning set.

The British singer headlined the first night of the festival, alongside Irish rock band Fontaines DC. It sounds like a fantastic start to the weekend's music!

ON AIR – Who would be your dream headliner for a big music festival?

MUSIC · THIS WEEK

4

The Grand Theft Auto 6 soundtrack reveal has revived the debate around digital music releases.

Fred Again, PinkPantheress, and Travis Scott are all providing new music for the blockbuster game. But not all fans are happy with how it's being rolled out.

ON AIR – When you're excited for new music, do you prefer a big, simultaneous release or a more staggered approach?

MUSIC · COMING UP

5

Welsh actor Matthew Rhys has spoken about his 'surreal' experience winning two lead acting prizes at the Emmy Awards.

He made history by becoming the first person to win two lead acting awards in one night. What an incredible achievement for British talent!

ON AIR – What's the most impressive double achievement you've ever heard of?

AWARDS · THIS WEEK

On the schedule

- 1 Rory McIlroy faltered late in his round, as Aaron Rai shares the lead at the BMW PGA Championship at Wentworth.**

Rai shot a superb six-under 66 to be tied with Sweden's Joakim Lagergren. It sets up an exciting weekend for British golf fans!

ON AIR – Who are you backing to take home the trophy at Wentworth this weekend?

GOLF · UK
- 2 Football rivalries are set to be renewed this weekend as several big derby games return to the Championship season.**

West Ham visit Millwall and Wolves host West Bromwich Albion in what promises to be fiery encounters. Derby days always bring extra passion!

ON AIR – What's the fiercest local derby in any sport that you can think of?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 3 Hooker Bryony Field will make her first start for England as the Red Roses take on Canada in the WXV Global Series.**

It's a rematch of last year's World Cup final, so expect a thrilling contest. England will be looking to continue their strong form.

ON AIR – Do you think England will dominate the WXV series this year?

RUGBY · UK
- 4 Six-time Grand Slam doubles champion Joe Salisbury has announced his retirement from professional tennis.**

The former world number one doubles player had an incredible career. It's always sad to see a great player hang up their racket.

ON AIR – Who is your favourite British tennis player of all time?

TENNIS · UK
- 5 Welsh cricketer Aneurin Donald is set to experience a special moment as he opens the batting for England in Cardiff.**

It's a homecoming for Donald, who will be playing in front of his home crowd. What a fantastic opportunity for him!

ON AIR – What's the most memorable sporting moment you've witnessed in person?

CRICKET · UK

Quick hits

- 1 Britons are keeping their phones for longer than ever before upgrading.**
The average handset is now held onto for several years. The main reason cited isn't loyalty — it's the dread of moving everything across.
- 2 More people are writing 'done lists' instead of to-do lists to feel better about their day.**
Noting what you actually achieved, however small, apparently beats staring at everything you didn't. 'Got dressed' counts.
- 3 A study says the smell of fresh bread is one of the few things almost everyone finds comforting.**
Supermarkets have long known it — the in-store bakery is no accident. Few of us escape without an unplanned loaf.
- 4 Almost two thirds of us say we've cried at a podcast in the last year — grief, parenting and identity top the list of triggers.**
Researchers reckon it's the intimacy of audio that does it. The figure is even higher for under-30s, 71% of whom admit a recent podcast-induced tear.
- 5 The fastest-growing hobby of 2026 is hand-embroidery — sales of needles and thread up 180% in a year.**
Crafters say it's the perfect 'phone detox' — slow, tactile, satisfying. TikTok is full of 20-somethings showing off custom denim jackets.
- 6 Cycling to the shops is up, with more people using bikes for short local trips rather than big rides.**
Councils credit better cycle lanes. The number one cargo carried? A surprisingly heavy single bag for life.
- 7 Roses are out, peonies are in — UK florists report a 200% rise in peony orders for weddings this summer.**
Brides cite 'softer, less staged' aesthetics. Wholesale peony prices have crept up accordingly.

05 — TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q 44% of us have done THIS while waiting for a kettle to boil. What?
ANSWER: WANDERED OFF AND FORGOTTEN ABOUT IT ENTIRELY.

Q 75% of us check THIS more than ten times a day. What?
ANSWER: THE WEATHER APP.

TALK TOPIC

- **A poll says most of us have a film we'll stop and watch no matter what part it's at.**
Which film reels you in every single time it's on?

- **Apparently we all have one word we can never spell right first time.**
What's the word that defeats you — even with autocorrect?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY — LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Science.** Hot water can freeze faster than cold water under certain conditions — an odd effect known as the Mpemba effect, still debated by scientists today.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** A university in Scotland has invented an umbrella that plays a gentle warning chime thirty seconds before it's about to turn inside out in the wind.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- Cows have best friends and get stressed when they're separated.
- The shortest commercial flight in the world lasts under two minutes, between two Scottish islands.
- Humans share about 60% of their DNA with bananas.
- Sloths can hold their breath longer than dolphins can.
- The word 'museum' comes from the Muses of Greek mythology.
- A single strand of spaghetti is called a 'spaghetto'.
- Nintendo was founded in 1889, originally making playing cards.
- Penguins propose to their mates with a pebble.

On this day

Day 261 of the year, 104 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Ariadne of Phrygia; Christian feast day: Constantius (Theban Legion); Christian feast day: Edward Bouverie Pusey (Episcopal Church); Christian feast day: Eustorgius I. Star sign Virgo, birthstone Sapphire.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1935 — John Spencer, English snooker player and sportscaster (died 2006)
- 1949 — Kerry Livgren, American guitarist and songwriter
- 1962 — John Fashanu, English footballer
- 1971 — Jada Pinkett Smith, American actress
- 1973 — James Marsden, American actor
- 1984 — Dizze Rascal, British hip hop musician
- 1946 — Nicholas Clay, English actor (died 2000)
- 1961 — Mark Olson, American singer-songwriter and guitarist

THE DAY TODAY

- 1997 — The Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention is adopted.
- 1977 — Voyager I takes the first distant photograph of the Earth and the Moon together.
- 2009 — After 72 years on radio and television, CBS Television broadcasts the final episode of Guiding Light, the longest-running soap opera in American history.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1980 — Soyuz 38 carries two cosmonauts (including one Cuban) to the Salyut 6 space station.
- 2015 — Two security personnel, 17 worshippers in a mosque, and 13 militants are killed during a Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan attack on a Pakistan Air Force base on the outskirts of Peshawar.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2010 — Philippe Croizon becomes the first quadruple amputee to swim across the English Channel.
- 2018 — Cannabis is legalized in South Africa, through a ruling of the Constitutional Court.
- 1990 — Liechtenstein becomes a member of the United Nations.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 262 of the year, 103 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Alonso de Orozco Mena; Christian feast day: Emilie de Rodat; Christian feast day: Blessed Francisca Cualladó Baixauli; Christian feast day: Goeric of Metz. Star sign Virgo, birthstone Sapphire.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1963 — Jarvis Cocker, English singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1993 — Pi'erre Bourne, American record producer and rapper
- 1995 — Rachel Sennott, American actress
- 1963 — David Seaman, English footballer
- 1931 — Brook Benton, American pop/R&B/rock & roll singer-songwriter (died 1988)
- 1941 — Jim Fox, English pentathlete (died 2023)
- 1953 — Sarana VerLin, American singer-songwriter and violinist
- 1973 — Nick Colgan, Irish footballer and coach

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1976 — Turkish Airlines Flight 452 hits the Taurus Mountains, outskirt of Karatepe, Turkey, killing all 154 passengers and crew.
- 1991 — Ötzi the Iceman is discovered in the Alps on the border between Italy and Austria.
- 2022 — The state funeral of Queen Elizabeth II of the United Kingdom is held at Westminster Abbey, London.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1985 — Tipper Gore and other political wives form the Parents Music Resource Center as Frank Zappa, John Denver, and other musicians testify at U.S. Congressional hearings on obscenity in rock music.
- 2021 — The Cumbre Vieja volcano, on the island of La Palma in the Canary Islands, erupts. The eruption lasts for almost three months, ending on December 13.

Coming to cinemas

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 18 The Black Phone 2

FRI 25 Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16 Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller

FRI 23 Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar